THE SPOON PROJECT

A carver's and collector's (almost) two-decades-long odyssey

BY BARRY GORDON AND NORMAN STEVENS PHOTOS BY RUDY HELLMANN

Many of the people who became part of the contemporary American crafts scene in the 1960s and 1970s saw it as an alternative to a mainstream culture and economy that wasn't particularly to their liking. In the alternative model, transactions were directly between the maker of an object and the person who would use it, and even when there was a go-between such as a gallery, the business often occurred on a relatively local and intimate scale. Over time, this craft model has been pushed by market forces back towards the mainstream, but despite that fact, it is still possible to create buyer-seller relationships that transcend the impersonal. Here is the story of one such relationship, told by the seller (spoonmaker Barry) and the buyer (collector Norman).

THE SPOONMAKER OBTAINS A BURL

Barry: This tale begins with a routine visit, sometime in 1984 or 1985, to the small local sawmill where I'd been getting roughsawn hard maple for my utensils. Two middle-aged brothers, who exhibited gruff exteriors over kind and generous interiors, operated the mill. They appreciated craftwork in general, and over the years, as I told them about spoonmaking, they developed an interest in my work.

Upon my arrival that day one of the brothers, Pete, asked, "You're interested in logs with those bumps (burls) on them, aren't you?" Anticipating my response, he continued with "Come here." I followed, assuming he was going to show me something in their log pile. Instead, he began walking rapidly out to the woodlot a hundred yards behind the mill. I trotted a few paces behind into the woods only to hear him say, "Damn, the ants got to it!" Still having no idea what he was talking about, I finally caught up and was astounded by a 48" diameter burl growing on a relatively small black cherry tree. It had several areas of insect damage and rot, but there was still more than half the burl of sound wood for making spoons. Pete's rhetorical "Do you want it?" sealed the deal.

A few weeks later the tree had been cut and was in the mill yard for my inspection and removal. I was actually relieved that the damage had occurred; otherwise, I would have felt obliged to forward the burl to a turner who could have used it for large bowls. This was my initial experience with a sizeable burl but, by following the arcs that separated the damaged wood from the orange section-like segments of good material, I was able to split out chunks appropriate for ladles and other spoons.

THE COLLECTORS

Norman: Shortly after my wife Nora and I moved to Connecticut in the fall of 1968, we developed an interest in contemporary American crafts. Since I was born and grew up in New Hampshire, I was aware of the League of New Hampshire Craftsmen's stores and annual fair. In the early 1970s we began attending the League Fair; subsequently we began visiting other craft fairs, including the American Craft Council Rhinebeck show that later moved to West Springfield, Massachusetts, and craft galleries in the Northeast and wherever else our travels have taken us.

At our first League Fair I purchased a small laurel bowl and probably at least one spoon from Dan Dustin, who had just begun exhibiting his work there. I became a regular purchaser of his spoons. As we attended craft fairs and galleries, I grew increasingly aware of work by other spoon carvers. I did not set out to become a wooden spoon collector, but that is where I have ended up.

MAKER AND COLLECTOR MEET

Barry: The first (and, ultimately, the largest) piece I carved from the burl was a 23" ladle completed in time for the 1985 ACC craft fair in West Springfield. I gave the ladle a prominent location in my display. During the preview evening, a man asked to see the ladle. He inspected it thoroughly and returned it to me, saying the oft-heard, seldom true, "I may be back." But Norman Stevens did return about twenty minutes later with his wife Nora, and they agreed to purchase the ladle. I told them about the burl, and asked if I could keep the ladle on display for the rest of the show. Norman and Nora, in what I have come to realize is their very understanding demeanor, agreed. I also remember Norman saying they might be interested in purchasing some future pieces made from that burl.

Norman: By that time my sensitivity to spoons had been heightened, even though my collection was still quite small. Nora and I had also developed the habit of trying to identify and purchase one-of-a-kind items created by craft exhibitors. I was immediately attracted to Barry's ladle. When I picked it up and felt how well-suited it was to my hand, I decided that it was definitely worth purchasing, but wanted to consult with Nora before spending $150 on a ladle. In addition to the shape, size, color, and design, I was especially attracted to the unusual triangular handle style that gave Barry's spoons their own identity. Barry explained the ladle's history, and I suggested that I might like to purchase the next spoon he made from that burl.

THE EIGHTEEN-YEAR COMMISSION

Norman: Shortly after I got home, I wrote to Barry and mentioned that I would be interested "in the possibility of acquiring the



A medley of Barry Gordon's utensils, made from one cherry burl for collector Norman Stevens.

entire set of items that you make from that burl." Barry wrote back a long letter, in which he described in more detail the origins and nature of the burl, the "12-15 spoons and ladles" that he might make from it, tentative prices, and indicated that "delivery on all dozen or so items could easily take a year." After we talked on the phone, I wrote to him, agreeing to purchase all of the items on "a right of first refusal basis."

Barry: After the show I shipped the ladle to the Stevens. Accompanying their payment was a note that led to a further exchange of correspondence and phone calls. We ultimately agreed that I would produce all the pieces from that burl for them. Although appreciative of this commission, I approached the project somewhat sporadically. I typically worked on one or two pieces at a time, saving potentially useful cut-offs for smaller items and always keeping the remaining pieces of wood segregated from the rest of my inventory. I'm not sure why I proceeded so irregularly; perhaps my highly-developed procrastination skills played a role. In any case, I soon realized that my one-year delivery schedule was a bit on the ambitious side. Only as I was finishing the last of the pieces 18 years later did I realize just how overly optimistic that estimate had been!

Norman and Nora never indicated any impatience, and I just let matters rest until times when I was particularly motivated to work on a piece. This slow pace yielded two benefits for the Stevens: they were never burdened with having to make multiple payments within a short period; and as my skills increased they received more refined work.


23" Ladle (1985)

Norman: Barry's estimate of the number of pieces proved to be too small, and his projection for the time it would take to complete the project was far too short. Over the next 18 years Barry and I maintained intermittent contact. I would see him occasionally at craft fairs, we would exchange notes, and when he had a new spoon or other piece completed, or near completion, he would let me know and then send it along on approval. Sometimes he sent a piece without notice. It turned out to be a wonderful arrangement. The sporadic arrival of a package from Barry always brought great anticipation. I was never disappointed with what he had created. The arrival of a new piece gave me the opportunity to get out the original ladle and the other pieces and to enjoy all of them anew. By the end of 2003, I had acquired 17 spoons, ladles, spreaders, and other utensils made by Barry from that single cherry burl. I thought that there might be only a few more pieces to come.

Barry: I recall meeting Norman or Nora only two or three more times, always at craft shows. We stayed in touch with handwritten correspondence that evolved into email messages, and occasional phone calls. Notes containing news of other spoonmakers whom Norman had seen often accompanied their checks. I consulted with him while creating the list of spoonmakers who would be invited to submit images for the Gallery presentation accompanying my article in the December 2000 issue of *Woodwork*.

PLANS FOR COMPLETION

Norman: We had talked from time to time about a visit to see Barry at his home in central New York, and of the possibility of bringing all of the pieces together to be photographed, but had never managed to do so. When Barry indicated to me in late 2003 that he had decided to complete the project, I realized that it would be possible to incorporate a visit to his home and workshop with a trip that Nora and I had planned for the summer of 2004.

Barry: I set the planned 2004 visit by the Stevens as the goal for completion of this odyssey. This task was a bit easier than it sounds because I had, for the most part, been using the largest chunks first and many of the utensils in the final group were smaller and, in some cases, simpler.

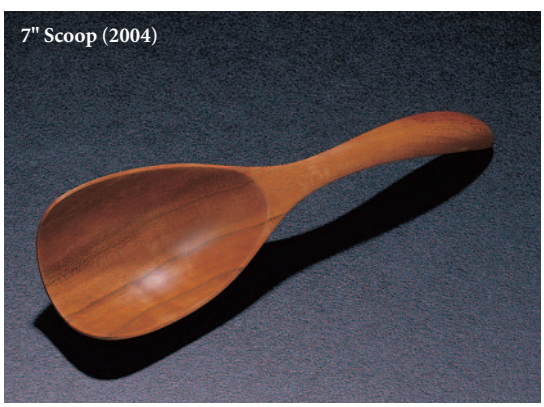
Norman had suggested that we might eventually write an article about the project. I immediately thought of my photographer friend Rudy Hellmann. We craftspeople always need high quality images of our work, and I (as well as some other area artists and craftspeople) am fortunate to have Rudy's superb services available as long as my needs can adjust to his schedule of other work. With Rudy, there is the added benefit that he is genuinely interested in how objects in a variety of media are produced, and photographing such work is not simply something he approaches mechanically.

THE VISIT

Norman: On Saturday June 26, we arrived in Baldwinsville, carrying with us a box containing the 17 cherry pieces then in my collection. We spent most of the day with Barry and Barbara admiring their collections and becoming acquainted. Finally, in the late afternoon, we laid out the pieces I had brought and Barry added an impressive 17 additional items that completed the project. It was a wonderful experience that gave all four of us the opportunity to see such a large group of diverse work made from a single burl and, in particular, to see the development and maturity of Barry's work over time. As he pointed out, the original ladle would have been much thinner had he created it near the end of the project.

Barry: I had anticipated the visit with three elements of apprehension. First, would we find Norman and Nora compatible visitors? Second, what would I think of my older work from a current perspective? And third, would I be able to complete the remaining pieces on time?

My wife Barbara and I have always considered getting to know the many interesting friends we've made in the craft world as a significant benefit of my career. These people, however, are almost exclusively other craftspeople and their families plus students I've taught; in this instance it was collectors whose visit we were anticipating. I got anxious about everything: my shop, our home, topics for conversation during the day-long visit. As it turned out, Norman and Nora were delightful guests, and we had plenty to discuss. I was also gratified when the knowledgeable Stevens clearly appreciated the visit we made to Syracuse to see Eureka Crafts, the gallery I had managed for eight years.


7" Scoop (2004)


11" Salad Servers (2004)

I've always viewed progress in my work as evolutionary, and I've never held the opinion that continuous change need be a primary criterion of quality in an artist or craftsperson's work nor even part of a definition of growth. When I looked over my older pieces I was able to view them in the context of when they had been produced and that item of concern also proved groundless.

The self-imposed deadline was a different story—I was anxiously working on some of the utensils right up to the night before the Stevens' arrival. All had been completed, but several were lacking one or more of the five coats of finish I use for my decorative spoons. This ultimately presented no problem, since I would be keeping them after our visit for photographing, but I couldn't resist chiding myself, "Here you've had an order for 19 years and you're still rushing to complete it the night before it's due!" Finally, in early September of 2004, I shipped all 34 of the utensils to their home in Storrs.

FINAL REFLECTIONS

Norman: Nora and I find that one of the greatest joys of collecting contemporary crafts is the opportunity it has given us to become closely acquainted with a substantial number of craftspeople whose work we collect and enjoy. In many cases those relationships have developed, as is the case with Barry, into friendships. While this particular project has come to an end, I am sure we will maintain our friendship with Barry and Barbara, and we will collect other of Barry's spoons.

Barry: The Stevens exemplify everything collectors should be. They have been patient, knowledgeable and discerning, completely trustworthy and not the least bit arrogant. It's daunting to realize that this project has lasted through such a major portion of my career as a maker and theirs as collectors. It is important, however, to also recognize that this relationship epitomizes what so many of us had hoped the craft world would offer as an alternative. It is sad to watch as the powerful mainstream has subsumed and distorted much of the current world of contemporary crafts, and to know that relationships such as the Stevens and I have maintained are potentially endangered.

Norman: There is one last portion of the project to be completed. I returned to Barry two small, unfinished pieces of the burl that he had given me as a keepsake. As soon as he sands and finishes them I plan to have a friend who does calligraphy see if she can suitably inscribe one of them with both of our names and the dates of the project that I can keep with the collection. I hope to arrange an exhibit of the entire collection in a suitable museum.

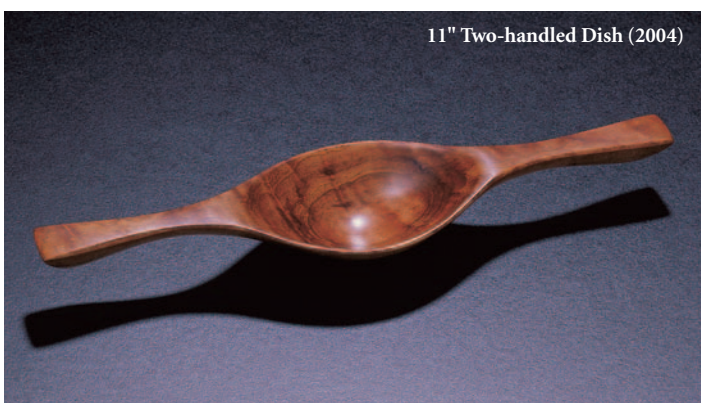
I am also looking around for something else to keep me, and others, occupied over a period of time. One possibility is to find another good-sized but smaller burl—perhaps black walnut—that might be distributed to 10-12 spoonmakers with the intent of acquiring a somewhat smaller collection of spoons all made from the same piece of wood but each by a different craftsperson. At 72 I'm hoping that might not take another 20 years.

Barry Gordon is in his 28th year of making wood spoons. He also teaches spoonmaking. Information about his work and workshops is available at: www.barrygordon.com

Norman D. Stevens is a collector of, among other contemporary crafts, wooden spoons and bowls. His spoon collection now contains approximately 175 items.

Rudy Hellmann is a commercial photographer who also creates fine art images and has a strong interest in contemporary and traditional crafts. More information about his work can be found at his website: www.rudyhellmann.com


15" and 18" Ladles (c. 1998)


11" Two-handled Dish (2004)


16" Dish (1999)


15" Spoon (2002)